
Why Endpoint Data Alone is Not Enough for an Effective XDR Strategy

Most XDR strategies start with endpoint data and most of them stop there too.

It all makes sense on the surface. Endpoints are where attacks usually land first, so that's where teams point their tools. But attacks don't sit still. They move off the device fast, and in a growing number of breaches, the endpoint agent doesn't even survive the attack. It gets disabled on purpose. Below we will discuss: why endpoint telemetry can't hold up an XDR security strategy on its own, the specific gaps that open up when it tries, and what an XDR implementation actually needs on top of it.

Key Takeaways

- Endpoints are where most attacks start. That doesn't make endpoint data enough to build an XDR strategy around on its own.
- EDRKillShifter, EDRSilencer, and EDRSandblast aren't evasion tools. They're built to kill the endpoint agent outright.
- Lateral movement, Unmanaged devices, Identity compromise and Cloud activity, none of them shows up if the endpoint is your only sensor.
- Collecting endpoint, network, identity, and cloud data isn't the hard part. Correlating it into one incident picture is what actually makes an XDR strategy work.
- Fidelis Elevate® ties Fidelis Endpoint®, Fidelis Network®, Active Directory Intercept™, and Fidelis Deception® together in one platform: correlated detection, automated response across all four.

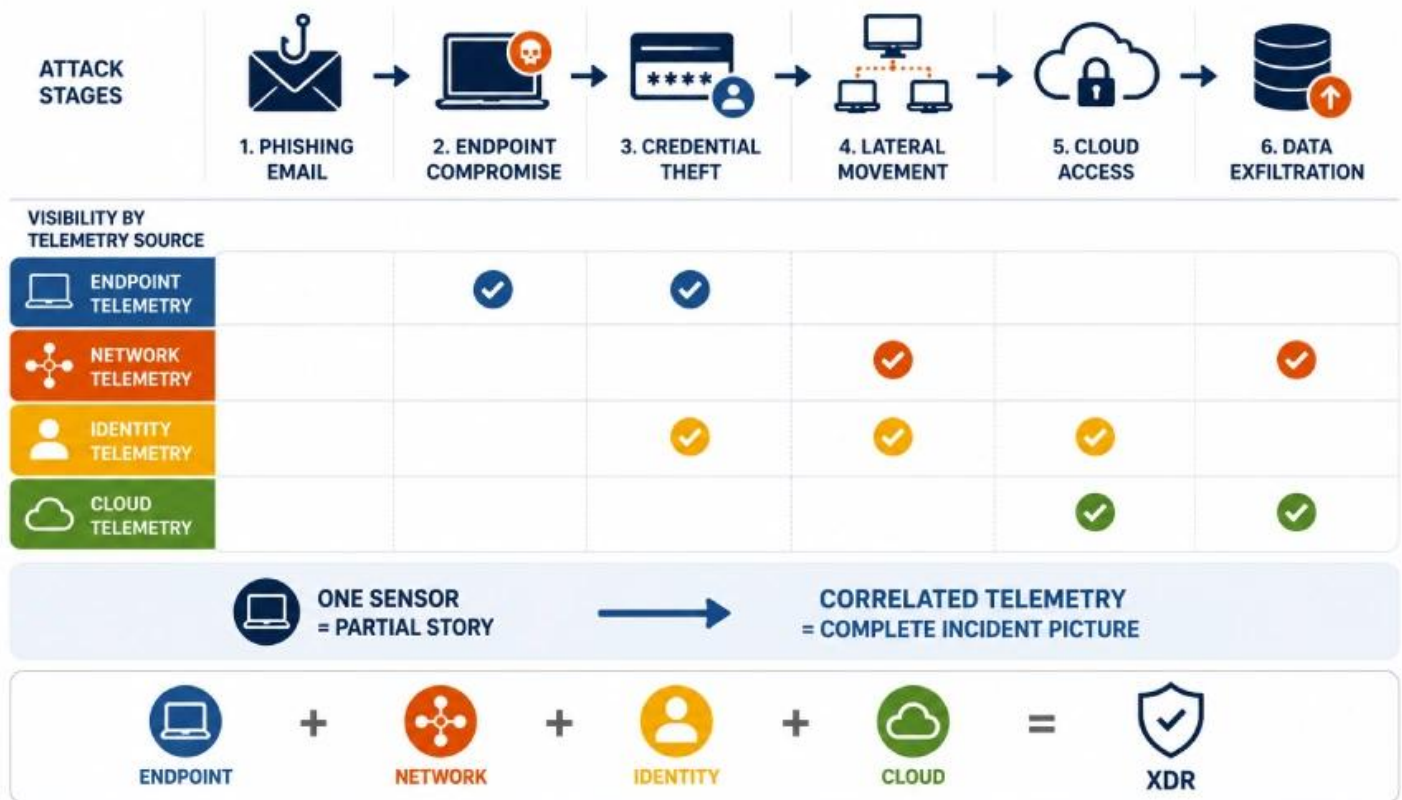
Why Do Security Teams Rely So Heavily on Endpoint Data in the First Place?

Look at where breaches actually originate and the numbers point to one place. Various studies put endpoints behind 90% of successful cyberattacks and 70% of data breaches. That's the number that turned [endpoint detection and response \(EDR\)](#) into the anchor of most security stacks, and why so many teams building out an XDR strategy start by pointing every other tool at endpoint data first.

That reliance is understandable. [Fidelis Endpoint](#)® delivers forensic and metadata collection across 300+ endpoint attributes, automated detection mapped to MITRE ATT&CK, and the ability to isolate a compromised device automatically. For a team building a detection program from scratch, endpoint visibility is usually the first, most defensible investment in EDR security.

WHY ENDPOINT DATA ALONE ISN'T ENOUGH FOR XDR

Modern attacks move fast—beyond what endpoint telemetry can see.



The problem starts when that first investment becomes the whole [extended detection and response](#) security program. Once endpoint telemetry is the only lens available, every decision, correlation, and response gets built around what one tool can see. A modern attack rarely stays inside that sensor's field of view for long, which is exactly why an effective XDR strategy can't be built on endpoint data alone.

Can Attackers Disable or Evade Endpoint Detection Tools?

Yes, and this is the part of the endpoint-data conversation that gets skipped most often. It isn't only that endpoint agents miss activity happening elsewhere. Attackers have built tools specifically to blind or kill the endpoint agent itself.

Security researchers have documented a growing category of "EDR killer" tools, including EDRKillShifter, EDRSilencer, EDRSandblast, variants of Terminator, and even the legitimate business application HRSword repurposed for the same job. These tools exploit the fact that any endpoint agent runs on the same operating system the attacker controls, contesting its visibility, disabling its drivers, or terminating its processes outright. Because EDR deployments tend to be uniform across environments, an exploit that defeats one installation tends to work everywhere that same agent runs.

A CISA Red Team assessment of a US critical infrastructure organization put this plainly. The team maintained access for months and reached its objectives, and the top lesson learned was that the organization had insufficient technical controls to prevent and detect malicious activity because it relied too heavily on host-based EDR without enough network-layer protection.

This is the sharpest argument against treating endpoint detection and response security event data as sufficient on its own. It isn't just incomplete, it's a target. Any XDR security strategy built

entirely on a sensor the attacker can disable has a single point of failure baked into its foundation.



Proactive Cyber Defense: Stay Ahead of Threats Reacting to attacks isn't enough—prevention is key. In this free guide, discover:

- Assessing Your Security Posture Prior to an Incident
- How Can Decision Makers Use the MITRE ATT&CK Framework?
- Beyond the MITRE Evaluation

[Read the Guide Now](#)

What Threats Does Endpoint-Only Monitoring Miss?

Even when the endpoint agent runs exactly as intended, its view stops at the device. Several categories of activity live almost entirely outside that view.

Lateral movement is the clearest example. Once inside, attackers increasingly use stolen credentials and legitimate system tools to move between machines, activity that shows up far more clearly through [network detection and response \(NDR\)](#) than in any single endpoint's process tree.

Unmanaged and unagentable devices are another gap. IoT devices, legacy systems, and some BYOD endpoints often cannot run an EDR agent at all, so they're invisible to endpoint-based detection by design, not by failure.

Identity is a third blind spot. Credential theft, [privilege escalation](#), and Active Directory compromise sit at the center of most modern breach chains, and these are identity events, not endpoint events.

Cloud security is the fourth: as infrastructure spreads across multi-cloud and hybrid environments, a growing share of what happens to an organization's data happens entirely off any managed endpoint, which is exactly why cloud XDR coverage matters as much as endpoint coverage.

None of these gaps are a flaw in EDR. They sit outside its job description. The mistake is asking one sensor to answer questions an effective XDR strategy needs answered elsewhere.

Does Your XDR Have the Data Needed for High-Confidence Detection?

Gartner's shorthand for XDR: a platform that automatically collects and correlates data from multiple security components. Two verbs, two very different levels of difficulty. Collecting is the easy half. Correlating, actually using that mix of endpoint, network, identity, email, and cloud data to catch something real, is where most deployments quietly fall apart. Detect, prioritize, automate the response. Simple to describe. Hard to run.

Here's why the correlation part matters so much. Say a phishing email lands and someone clicks it. A credential gets stolen off the back of that click. The stolen credential turns up moving between machines on the network. Not long after, data starts flowing out through a cloud app. Four separate signals, spread across four systems. Looked at individually, none of them scream "breach." Lined up next to each other, they tell one clear story about an intrusion in progress.

A platform watching only the endpoint sees the first signal and stops there. It has nothing else to line it up against, so all it can do is get incrementally better at spotting the same kind of thing it already spots. That's EDR wearing an XDR badge. It isn't extended detection and response security in any meaningful sense.

Ask this instead when evaluating an XDR strategy: forget the volume of endpoint data coming in. Is there enough range across sources, endpoint, network, identity, and cloud to actually back a high-confidence call the moment an alert fires?

Building an XDR Strategy That Goes Beyond Endpoint Data

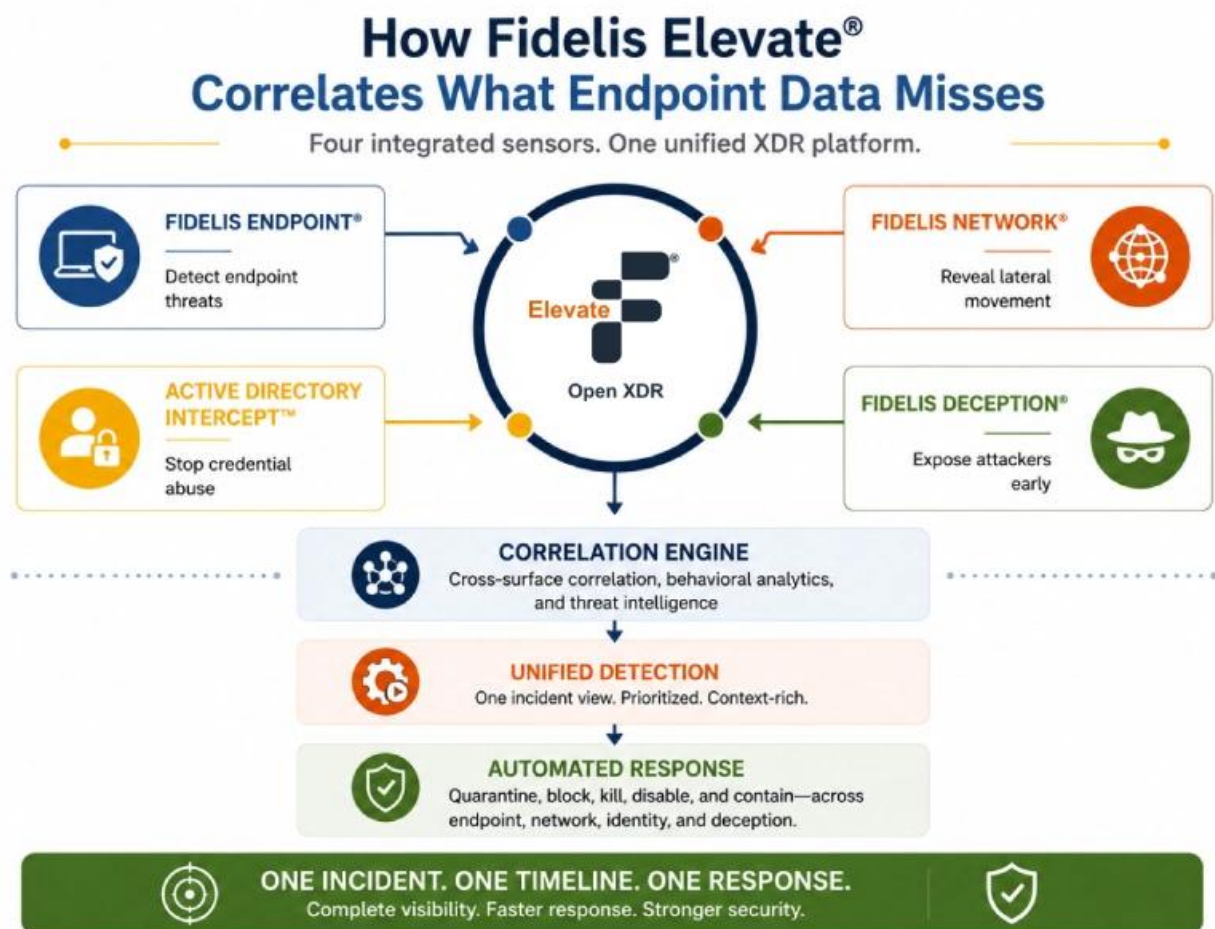
Start with where the data comes from. Network traffic, identity and Active Directory logs, cloud workload data, email telemetry, none of that should show up as an afterthought once endpoint data has already been flowing for months. Treat it as a first-class input from day one of XDR deployment. Waiting until an incident exposes the gap is how most of these gaps get found in the first place.

Getting the data in the door solves nothing by itself. A data lake full of raw telemetry doesn't detect a single thing on its own. Someone has to apply correlation rules, [behavioral analytics](#), and machine learning across every source, consistently, so a suspicious login sitting next to a suspicious network connection actually gets read as one event instead of two nobody bothers to connect.

Then there's response, and this is the piece most XDR best practices lists skip over. Automation has to reach every domain the platform touches, not stop at the endpoint. Isolating a compromised device is a reasonable first move. It won't matter much if the attacker already has a foothold in the network or a compromised Active Directory account sitting untouched. [XDR incident response](#) only works if it covers as much ground as detection does.

How Does Fidelis Elevate® Solve the Endpoint Data Problem?

[Fidelis Elevate](#)® was built around exactly this principle: unify the sensors instead of stacking them. The platform combines Fidelis Endpoint®, Fidelis Network®, Active Directory Intercept™, and Fidelis Deception® in one system rather than treating network or identity visibility as an add-on to an endpoint-first product.



[Fidelis Network](#)® performs session-level inspection across all 65,535 network ports, giving the platform genuine network detection and response coverage that catches lateral movement and command-and-control traffic regardless of whether the device involved is running an agent at all. This closes exactly the gap that EDR-killer tools try to exploit. [Active Directory Intercept](#)™ covers the identity layer directly, watching for the credential theft and privilege escalation that sit at the center of most breach chains.

[Fidelis Deception](#)® adds cyber deception assets, decoys that reveal an attacker's presence and intent before they reach anything of real value, which matters most in the exact scenario the CISA Red Team report describes: an attacker with quiet, sustained access that endpoint monitoring alone never surfaced.

All of it correlates through one platform, so an analyst isn't manually connecting an endpoint

alert to a network alert to an identity alert. Fidelis Elevate® can also automatically quarantine a compromised system, freeze network traffic, kill a malicious process, and disable a compromised administrator account as a single coordinated response, rather than requiring a human to stitch that sequence together mid-incident.

What Should an Effective XDR Strategy Actually Include?

Endpoint data is a strong foundation, not a complete XDR strategy. It's necessary because that's where most attacks start, and it's insufficient because attackers now treat the endpoint agent itself as a target, and because a large share of what a modern breach touches, network movement, identity abuse, cloud activity, never crosses that one sensor's view.

An effective XDR strategy needs telemetry that doesn't depend on a single host staying uncompromised, a platform that correlates across that telemetry rather than just storing it, and [response automation](#) that reaches every domain an attacker can touch. Fidelis Elevate® was built to deliver exactly that: endpoint, network, identity, and deception, unified and correlated in one platform, so a compromised or disabled endpoint agent is a setback, not a blind spot.

Don't let Threats go Unnoticed. See how Fidelis Elevate® helps you:

- Identify and neutralize threats faster
- Gain full visibility across your attack surface
- Automate security operations for efficiency

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DATA SHEET

Fidelis Elevate

Think Like the Adversary.

Datasheet

Everything about modern compute environments blurs the digital transformation initiatives within surfaces. Data is everywhere. Adversaries give sophisticated and precise. The only part of this the same-or similar-to the staff and resources have in place to combat cyberattacks. That's the business, and integrated security operations (cyber readiness) and that's where Fidelis Elevate.

How Fidelis Elevate Works

Fidelis Elevate is the powerhouse of your IT and your security stack. This open and soft and Resilient (C2M) platform is purpose-built defense. Fidelis Elevate provides context-based detection to speed threat detection, further the entire environment. Fidelis Elevate get security intelligence for IT, IoT, data center, single view. Security operations can easily perform deep inspection and analysis of a business continuity through an attack, and normal business operations as quickly as

Fidelis Elevate

Open XDR Built



Fidelis Elevate
Think Like the Adversary.
Be Ready for Anything.